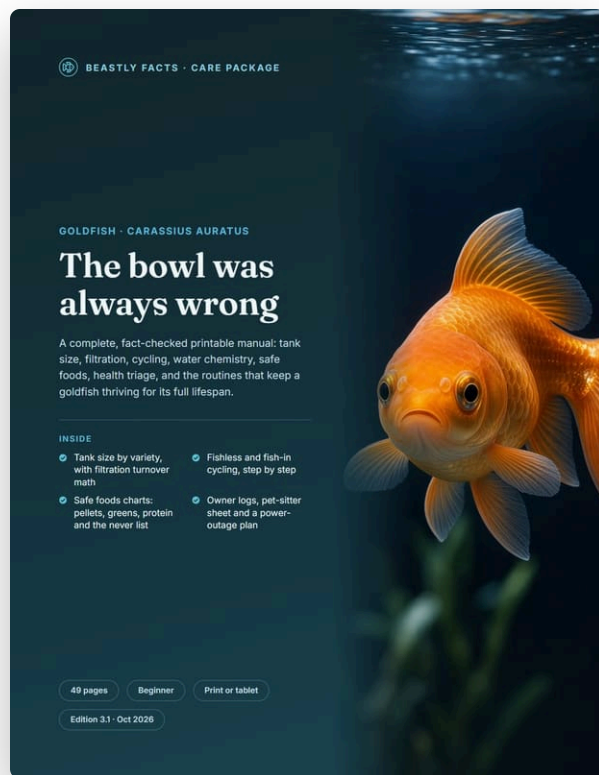


FREE SAMPLE

Goldfish Care Package

The first 5 pages of the 49-page printable manual, free to keep.



In this sample: What's inside, How to Use This Package, Quick Profile & Cost Overview, The Goldfish, Varieties, Size & Lifespan. The contents page shows every one of the 49 pages, so you can see exactly what the full package covers before you buy it.

Not in this sample: the 44 pages that follow, which are the full care guide, the health section, the quick reference cards, and the owner tools, checklists and logs.

The full package is \$8.99 at beastlyfacts.com/care-packages/goldfish/. One purchase, and every corrected edition is a free re-download from your library. The free goldfish care guide it was built from is at beastlyfacts.com/guides/goldfish/, and stays free.

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Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

UNITS USED THROUGHOUT

Every temperature and size is given twice. Temperatures appear in degrees Fahrenheit (°F) with degrees Celsius (°C) beside them. Lengths appear in inches (in) and feet (ft) with centimeters (cm) beside them, and the smallest in millimeters (mm). Weight is in pounds (lb). Tank volume appears in gallons (gal) with liters (L) beside it, small doses in milliliters (ml), and filter flow in gallons per hour (gph). Water test results are written in ppm (parts per million) or mg/L (milligrams per liter), two ways of writing the same strength of a dissolved substance in water. Prices are in United States dollars.

If you haven't set up yet

Read pages 6 to 13 in order before buying anything. The tank and the filter shape the next decade, and both are cheaper to get right the first time. Buy the tank before the fish, and plan on four to six weeks of fishless cycling (growing the bacteria that process waste) before a goldfish goes in. Then use the budget and shopping list on pages 35 to 36 to buy once.

If your goldfish is already set up

Audit what you have against the Setup Checklist on page 33, and go to the Red Flags page (27) if anything seems off. Test the water first. Most goldfish problems that look like disease are a water reading.

If you already have a fish in an uncycled tank

This is the most common situation, and it is fixable. Go to the fish-in cycle on page 10. Do not tear the tank down or start dosing treatments: daily testing and water changes carry you through it.

Print these first

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Page 33: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 41: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 34: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 42: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 38: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 43: Equipment & Vet Log |
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WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

The bowl, the line that a goldfish grows to fit its tank, and the three-second memory are still repeated, and all three are wrong. This package replaces them with numbers you can test against, drawn from the veterinary and university sources on page 47.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

A veterinarian who treats fish. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care, and anything urgent is a vet call. Most small-animal clinics do not see fish, so find a fish vet before you need one.

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Carassius auratus</i> , bred from the Prussian carp
Adult size	Fancy varieties 6 to 8 in (15 to 20 cm); shubunkin 10 to 12 in (25 to 30 cm); common and comet 10 to 14+ in (25 to 36+ cm). Pond fish have passed 18 in (46 cm)
Captive lifespan	10 to 15 years in a well-kept tank, 20 to 30+ in a spacious pond. The record is 43 years
Origin	Bred in China over a thousand years ago from a wild carp relative
Diet type	Omnivore: a sinking goldfish pellet as the staple, with vegetables and protein foods alongside (page 14)
Tank minimum (adult)	20 gal (76 L) for one fancy, plus 10 gal (38 L) per extra fish; 40 gal (151 L) for a shubunkin; 55 gal (208 L) for one common or comet, and a pond is better
Water temperature	65 to 75°F (18 to 24°C). A coldwater fish: no heater unless the room falls below that
Water chemistry	Ammonia 0, nitrite 0, nitrate under 20 ppm, pH 6.5 to 7.5 (page 11)
Filtration minimum	The tank's volume turned over 10 times an hour or more (page 8)
Sexual maturity	About one year, with the prime years around the third (page 24)
Handling difficulty	Not a hands-on pet. Container transfers, a soft fine-mesh or rubber net, never bare hands (page 19)
Social needs	Social: generally does better with its own kind than alone
Conservation status	Domesticated and not evaluated; the wild ancestor is Least Concern, the lowest-risk grade on the global list of threatened species

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$310 to \$615 for the equipment, quarantine tank and first food, plus under \$10 for the fish itself, more for a fancy variety, so about \$310 to \$625 all in. Every line is on page 35.

Monthly ongoing

\$10 to \$30 a month to top up pellets, occasional gel or frozen food, and dechlorinator and other water treatments.

THE CHEAPEST ANIMAL IN THE STORE, ONE OF THE COSTLIEST FISH TO HOUSE

The fish costs next to nothing. The money is in the tank and the filter, and the expensive mistake is buying the cheap bowl first and the correct tank six months later, alongside a sick fish.

Fun facts worth knowing

- Goldfish form associative memories that last months and can be trained to push levers for food and navigate mazes, which makes the three-second memory line backwards.
- A goldfish has no true stomach, so food passes along the gut: small portions suit it, and one large meal does not.
- Goldfish and koi can be crossed, mostly by artificial spawning, and the first-generation hybrid males examined were sterile.

The goldfish, varieties, size & lifespan

What you are buying, how big it gets, and how long it stays.

One species, a thousand years of breeding

Every pet goldfish is *Carassius auratus*, bred in China from a wild carp relative for color mutations noted as early as the Jin dynasty (266 to 420). Moving the fish indoors in the Ming dynasty let breeders keep fancy-tailed mutations too fragile for an outdoor pond. The result is dozens of varieties, from the streamlined common and comet to the round-bodied oranda and ranchu.

Which goldfish do you actually have

TYPE	ADULT SIZE	MINIMUM FOR ONE	NOTES
Fancy: oranda, ranchu and other round-bodied varieties	6 to 8 in (15 to 20 cm)	20 gal (76 L), plus 10 gal (38 L) each	Round-bodied. Swim bladder trouble is most common in this group, and delicate fins need smooth surroundings. Some varieties, telescope eye among them, are bred with prominent eyes.
Shubunkin	10 to 12 in (25 to 30 cm)	40 gal (151 L)	A larger tank of 55 gal (208 L) or more, or a pond, is the better setup.
Common and comet	10 to 14+ in (25 to 36+ cm)	55 gal (208 L)	The single-tail fish sold as feeders. A feeder is the same species as a pet goldfish, and it is better suited to a pond than an indoor tank in the long run.

Size: it does not fit the tank

Goldfish do not stay small to match their container. A small tank stunts them: poor water, chronic ammonia and cramped space suppress outward growth while the organs and skeleton keep developing, linked to shortened lives and organ failure. In outdoor ponds with excellent water, goldfish regularly reach 12 in (30 cm) or more. The small goldfish most people picture is a stunted one.

Lifespan

Ten to 15 years is normal in a well-kept tank and 20 to 30 or more in a spacious pond. The oldest on record, a male named Tish, lived from 1956 to 1999, 43 years. That makes a goldfish a decade-long commitment.

Company

Goldfish are social and generally do better with their own kind than alone. Keep fancy with fancy and single-tail with single-tail, so that body shape and swim speed match and competition at feeding time stays low. A tropical tank is the wrong home for it: a goldfish needs cool water, and guppies and anything slower at the food are the pairings that fail.

GOLDFISH OR KOI?

They are different species. A koi has two pairs of whisker-like barbels at the corners of its mouth, and a goldfish has none. A goldfish can carry koi herpesvirus without showing signs and pass it to koi, so a goldfish added to a koi pond is quarantined like a new koi.